

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track A

AI & Emerging Technology Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 A track: Tech / AI. Produce a decision-ready governance package for a frontier-tech policy gap.

Use Case Description:

Frontier AI and emerging technologies are outpacing the policy infrastructure meant to govern them. This challenge asks teams to act as a rapid-response policy shop: take an unresolved emerging-tech governance question and produce a decision-ready package for a congressional office, federal agency, or think tank client.

Problem Statement:

Producing a decision-ready governance package for a frontier-tech policy gap.

- Select a governance gap (e.g., AI model evaluation standards, biosecurity screening for synthetic DNA, critical infrastructure cybersecurity, semiconductor export controls).
- Map the current regulatory/legislative landscape and identify the specific gap or conflict.
- Identify stakeholders (agencies, industry, civil society, international bodies) and their positions.
- Draft a policy option set with tradeoffs (not just one recommendation).
- Stress-test the proposal against a plausible adversarial or edge-case scenario.

Possible Approaches:

- Legislative drafting — model bill language plus a section-by-section explainer.
- Regulatory — an agency rulemaking proposal (NIST, FTC, CISA-style) with cost-benefit analysis.
- Comparative — benchmark against EU AI Act, UK, or Japan frameworks.
- Red-team — build the proposal around a specific failure mode/incident scenario.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy memo (executive-summary style)

- One-page issue brief / “leave-behind”
- Slide deck (8–10 slides) for a 10-minute briefing
- Annotated bibliography or source list
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Model legislative or regulatory text (redlined)
- Cost/fiscal impact or CBO-style scoring exercise
- Short (2–3 min) recorded elevator-pitch video
- Public-comment-style submission to a real open rulemaking

Platforms and Tools:

- Legislative tracking: Congress.gov, Regulations.gov, GovTrack
- Comparative policy databases: OECD.AI Policy Observatory, EU AI Act tracker
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, Notion, or a shared repo
- Optional data/analysis: Python or R

Judging Criteria:

- Policy feasibility & political viability — **25%**
- Technical accuracy — **20%**
- Clarity & persuasiveness of writing/briefing — **20%**
- Stakeholder analysis depth — **15%**
- Originality of approach — **10%**
- Handling of tradeoffs/edge cases — **10%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public, cite-able sources (statutes, agency filings, peer-reviewed research, reputable news).
- No non-public government data, leaked documents, or personal data on named private individuals.
- Disclose any AI-assisted drafting in an appendix.
- No fictionalized dialogue or misattributed quotes to real public officials.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.